

EthioWheels — Business Proposal

Ethiopia's First Verified EV Marketplace & Trust Platform

Prepared by: Solo Founder (Software Developer) **Date:** May 2026 **Stage:** Pre-launch / Bootstrapped **Investment Required:** ETB 0 (Zero external capital)

Table of Contents

1. Executive Summary
 2. Ethiopia's Current Automotive Reality
 3. The Problem We Solve
 4. The Opportunity
 5. Our Solution
 6. Competitive Landscape
 7. Business Model & Revenue
 8. Go-to-Market Strategy (Zero Budget)
 9. Challenges & How We Overcome Them
 10. Technology Plan
 11. Financial Projections
 12. Risks
 13. 12-Month Roadmap
 14. Future Vision (Year 2–5)
 15. Why This Wins
-

1. Executive Summary

Ethiopia is in the middle of the most dramatic automotive transition any country has ever undertaken. In January 2024, it became the **first country in the world to ban the import of internal combustion engine (ICE) vehicles**. As of 2026, over 100,000 electric vehicles are on Ethiopian roads — 8.3% of all registered vehicles — ahead of the United States (2.7%) and India (0.5%).

Yet the used EV market operates almost entirely through **WhatsApp groups, Telegram channels, and roadside dealers** with no verification, no battery health data, no standardized pricing, and no financing infrastructure built for EVs.

EthioWheels is a verified EV marketplace that solves the trust problem at the center of Ethiopia's used EV market. We inspect cars, issue battery health reports, connect buyers to financing, and map charging infrastructure — all built and operated by a single software developer with zero starting capital.

This is not a speculative idea. The market exists today. The pain is real today. The technology to build it costs nothing today.

2. Ethiopia's Current Automotive Reality

2.1 The EV Revolution Is Already Here

Metric	Value	Source
ICE import ban enacted	January 2024	Ethiopian Government
EVs on Ethiopian roads (2026)	~100,000	Ministry of Transport
EV share of registered vehicles	8.3%	Ministry of Transport
Government EV target by 2030	500,000	National E-Mobility Strategy
Charging stations mandated by 2030	2,300	IEA / Ethiopian Government
Current public fast-charging hubs	4 (all Ethio Telecom)	CleanTechnica 2026
Used car market size (2026)	~\$494 million USD	Mordor Intelligence
Grid energy source	96% renewable (hydro)	IRENA

2.2 What Is Driving This

- Ethiopia banned ICE imports with **no transition period** — the most aggressive EV policy globally
- The government is redirecting **\$4.5 billion/year** previously spent on fuel imports into green development
- Ethio Telecom, the national telecom giant, is actively building EV charging infrastructure
- BYD, Chery, and other Chinese EV brands are flooding the market with affordable vehicles
- Ethiopia is being watched globally as **Africa's EV blueprint**

2.3 The Digital Landscape

- Mobile internet penetration is growing rapidly (World Bank-supported digital expansion)
- Telebirr (Ethio Telecom's mobile money) has tens of millions of users
- Chapa, ArifPay, and BirrPay provide developer-friendly payment APIs
- Telegram is the dominant platform for informal commerce in Ethiopia
- mekina.net is the only notable car listing site — generic, not EV-focused, no verification

2.4 The Gap Nobody Has Filled

There is **no platform in Ethiopia** that: - Focuses exclusively on electric vehicles - Provides battery health inspection and scoring - Issues verified condition reports - Connects EV buyers to EV-aware financing - Maps real-time charging station availability

This gap is the business.

3. The Problem We Solve

3.1 The Buyer's Problem: "I Don't Know What I'm Buying"

When an Ethiopian buyer looks at a used EV today, they face:

- **No battery health data.** A 3-year-old BYD Atto 3 might have 95% battery capacity or 60%. There is no way to know without specialized diagnostics. Sellers don't disclose this. Buyers don't know to ask.
- **No vehicle history.** Was this car in an accident? Was the odometer rolled back? Nobody knows.
- **No price reference.** EV pricing in Ethiopia is entirely negotiation-based. Buyers routinely overpay by 20–40%.
- **No recourse.** Transactions happen cash-in-hand. If the car breaks down the next day, the buyer has no protection.

Result: Buyers are scared. Many delay purchasing or buy ICE cars on the grey market instead of EVs.

3.2 The Seller's Problem: "Nobody Trusts My Car"

Honest sellers with genuinely good EVs cannot prove their car's quality:

- No inspection certificate exists in Ethiopia for EVs
- Buyers lowball aggressively because they assume the worst
- Deals fall through repeatedly before a sale closes
- Sellers waste weeks negotiating with unserious buyers

Result: Good cars sit unsold. Sellers lose money on price. The market is inefficient.

3.3 The Bank's Problem: "We Can't Lend on EVs"

Ethiopian banks want to finance EV purchases but face a structural problem:

- Traditional car loan terms (10+ years) don't apply to EVs due to battery degradation uncertainty
- Banks currently cap EV loans at under 5 years — making monthly payments unaffordable
- No standardized EV valuation methodology exists in Ethiopia

- Banks cannot assess residual value without battery health data

Result: EV financing is scarce, expensive, and short-term. This suppresses demand.

3.4 The Fleet Operator’s Problem: “I’m Flying Blind”

Ride-hail operators (Ride, ZayRide) and taxi fleet owners managing 10–100 EVs have:

- No tool to track battery health across their fleet
- No charging cost analytics
- No maintenance prediction
- No centralized vehicle management

Result: Fleet operators make decisions based on guesswork, leading to unexpected breakdowns and revenue loss.

4. The Opportunity

4.1 Why Now

The timing is not coincidental — it is structural:

1. **The ICE ban created a forced transition.** Every new vehicle sold in Ethiopia from 2024 onward is electric. The used EV market will grow exponentially as these vehicles age and change hands.
2. **No incumbent has moved.** mekina.net is generic and slow. Autochek and Cheki have not entered Ethiopia. The field is open.
3. **Government alignment.** Any platform that supports EV adoption is aligned with national policy. This means potential grants, partnerships, and regulatory goodwill.
4. **Trust vacuum.** The first platform to establish trust in this market owns the market. Trust is a moat that takes years to build and is nearly impossible to copy quickly.

4.2 Market Size

Segment	Current Size	2030 Projection
Used EV transactions/year (est.)	~15,000–20,000	~80,000–100,000
Average transaction value	ETB 1.5M–4M	ETB 2M–5M
Addressable listing fee market	ETB 7.5M–15M/year	ETB 40M–80M/year
Inspection market	ETB 15M–30M/year	ETB 80M–160M/year

Segment	Current Size	2030 Projection
Financing referral market	ETB 30M–75M/year	ETB 200M–500M/year

Even capturing **2–3% of this market** by year 3 is a sustainable, profitable business.

5. Our Solution

5.1 Product Overview

EthioWheels is a **verified EV marketplace** with four interconnected products:

Product 1: Verified EV Listings

- EV-only listings (no ICE cars — this is the brand promise)
- Structured EV-specific data: battery health %, estimated range, charge cycles, model year
- Amharic and English interface
- Mobile-first design (Android-optimized)
- Seller contact via Telegram/WhatsApp (familiar to Ethiopian users)
- “Verified” badge for inspected vehicles

Product 2: EV Battery Health Report

- Seller requests an inspection through the platform
- Our partner mechanic visits the car with an OBD2 diagnostic tool
- We generate a standardized PDF report: battery health score (0–100), estimated remaining range, charge cycle count, any fault codes
- Report is attached to the listing permanently
- Buyers can trust the number because we issued it, not the seller

Product 3: Financing Connector

- “Apply for Financing” button on every listing
- Buyer fills a simple form (income, employment, down payment)
- We route the lead to our bank/MFI partner
- Bank contacts buyer directly
- We earn a referral fee per converted loan

Product 4: Charging Station Map

- Interactive map of all EV charging stations in Ethiopia
- Crowdsourced updates (users report new stations, broken chargers)
- Station details: connector type, speed, cost, operating hours

- Grows in value as charging infrastructure expands toward the 2,300-station target

5.2 What Makes It Different

We are not building another car listing site. We are building **the trust layer** for Ethiopia's EV market. The listing is just the entry point. The inspection report, the financing connection, and the charging map are what create lock-in and defensibility.

6. Competitive Landscape

6.1 Direct Competitors in Ethiopia

Platform	Type	EV Focus	Inspection	Financing	Verdict
mekina.net	Generic car listings	Mixed	None	None	Weak, generic
Telegram channels	Informal groups	Mixed	None	None	No trust layer
Facebook groups	Informal	Mixed	None	None	No trust layer
Roadside dealers	Physical	Partial	Informal	Informal	No scale

Conclusion: There is no real direct competitor for a verified EV-specific platform in Ethiopia.

6.2 African Benchmarks (What We Learn From)

Company	Country	What They Did	Lesson
Cars45	Nigeria	Physical inspection hubs + instant valuation	Inspection = trust = market share
Autochek	Pan-Africa	Financing marketplace on top of listings	Financing 3x revenue per transaction
Cheki Kenya	Kenya	12,000+ listings/month, 700K monthly users	Scale comes from dealer network

Company	Country	What They Did	Lesson
Vinlogs	Kenya	Blockchain vehicle history verification	Data integrity is a product
Shekel Mobility	Nigeria	B2B dealer marketplace, raised \$7M	Dealers are the supply side

6.3 Global Benchmarks

Company	Country	Revenue	Lesson
Carvana	USA	\$20B+	Full-stack trust + convenience = premium pricing
Recurrent	USA	Growing	Battery health reports for used EVs — our direct product inspiration
PlugShare	Global	Acquired	Crowdsourced charging data has real value
CarGurus	USA	\$1B+	Data-driven pricing transparency builds buyer trust

Key insight from all benchmarks: The winner is always the platform that solves **trust**, not the one with the most listings.

7. Business Model & Revenue

7.1 Core Principle: Earn From Day One, Spend Nothing

Because we have zero investment, every revenue stream must be: - **Collectible immediately** (no “we’ll monetize later”) - **Requiring no upfront cost** to deliver - **Scalable without hiring**

7.2 Revenue Streams

Stream 1: Listing Fees (Starts Month 1)

Tier	Price (ETB)	What Seller Gets
Free	0	1 listing, 3 photos, 30 days, no phone shown
Basic	200	5 photos, 60 days, phone number visible
Premium	500	Featured on homepage, 10 photos, 90 days, Premium badge
Dealer Monthly	2,000	Unlimited listings, dealer profile page, priority support

Payment collected via **Chapa** (supports Telebirr, CBE Birr, Awash, bank transfer).

The free tier exists to build supply. The paid tiers exist to earn revenue. Sellers who get inquiries from free listings will upgrade.

Stream 2: Inspection Referral Fee (Starts Month 3) We do not do inspections ourselves. We partner with mechanics.

How it works: 1. Seller clicks “Get Verified” on their listing and pays ETB 800–1,500 2. We notify our partner mechanic (via Telegram/WhatsApp) 3. Mechanic visits the car, runs OBD2 diagnostics, fills our standardized form 4. We generate the PDF battery health report automatically 5. Report is attached to the listing; “Verified” badge appears 6. We pay the mechanic ETB 600–1,000 and keep ETB 200–500 per inspection

Our role: Software + coordination. Zero physical work.

Stream 3: Financing Lead Referral (Starts Month 4) **How it works:** 1. Buyer clicks “Apply for Financing” on any listing 2. Fills a 5-field form (name, phone, income, employment, down payment %) 3. We send the lead to our bank/MFI partner via email or API 4. Bank contacts buyer, processes loan 5. Bank pays us ETB 500–1,500 per converted loan

Target partners: Awash Bank, Abyssinia Bank, Oromia Cooperative Bank, local MFIs. **Pitch to bank:** “We send you pre-qualified EV buyers. You pay only on conversion.”

Stream 4: Charging Station Data (Year 2)

- Sell aggregated, anonymized charging usage data to fleet operators, insurance companies, and government planners
- Offer a premium API for fleet management software
- SaaS subscription: ETB 500–2,000/month per fleet operator

7.3 Unit Economics Per Transaction

Action	Revenue	Cost	Margin
Premium listing	ETB 500	ETB 0	100%
Dealer monthly	ETB 2,000	ETB 0	100%
Inspection referral	ETB 300 avg	ETB 0	100%
Financing referral	ETB 800 avg	ETB 0	100%

Because we have no physical operations, **every birr earned is nearly pure margin** in the early stage.

8. Go-to-Market Strategy (Zero Budget)

8.1 The Core Problem: No Network, No Money, No Brand

This is the hardest part. Here is the honest, step-by-step approach.

8.2 Phase 1: Build Supply Before Launch (Week 1–3)

The chicken-and-egg problem: Buyers won't come without listings. Sellers won't list without buyers.

Solution: Fake the supply first.

1. Join every Ethiopian car Telegram channel (CarMax, BeshBesh Cars, etc.)
2. Contact sellers directly: "I'm building a verified EV platform. Can I list your car for free? I'll send you any inquiries."
3. Manually post their listings on the site (with permission)
4. The site looks active from day one
5. Real sellers see activity and list themselves
6. Replace manual listings with real ones over time

This is exactly what Airbnb did in 2008 — they manually photographed apartments in New York to seed their supply.

8.3 Phase 2: Launch Channels (Week 4, Zero Cost)

Channel	Action	Expected Reach
Telegram	Post in 10+ Ethiopian car groups	5,000–20,000 people
Facebook	Post in Ethiopian car buy/sell groups	10,000–50,000 people

Channel	Action	Expected Reach
TikTok/YouTube	Short video: “How to check EV battery health before buying”	Organic reach
Word of mouth	Ask every seller to share with 3 friends	Compounding
mekina.net	List your platform in their comments/forum	Targeted audience

Key message: “Ethiopia’s first EV-only verified marketplace. List free. Get a battery health report.”

8.4 Phase 3: Build Credibility (Month 2–3)

- Publish 3–5 educational articles in Amharic: “How to buy a used EV in Ethiopia,” “What is battery health?”, “EV financing guide”
- These rank on Google and bring organic traffic forever
- Share in Telegram channels as helpful content, not ads
- Partner with 1–2 EV influencers or YouTubers in Ethiopia for a feature

8.5 Phase 4: Dealer Outreach (Month 3–4)

- Identify the top 20 EV dealers in Addis Ababa
- Visit them in person (or call) with a simple pitch: “List all your EVs free for 2 months. If you get inquiries, pay ETB 2,000/month after.”
- Dealers have 10–50 cars each — one dealer deal = 10–50 listings instantly
- This solves the supply problem permanently

8.6 The “No Network” Advantage

Having no network forces you to build in public and earn trust organically. This is actually better than paid advertising because: - Organic trust is more durable than paid attention - Content you create today keeps working for years - Community members who find you organically become your strongest advocates

9. Challenges & How We Overcome Them

This section is honest. These are real obstacles, not hypothetical ones.

Challenge 1: “mekina.net already exists”

The threat: mekina.net has existing traffic, brand recognition, and listings. Why would sellers switch?

The reality: mekina.net is a generic classifieds site. It lists ICE cars, motorcycles, and EVs together with no differentiation. It has no inspection, no battery health data, no EV filters, no financing. It is Craigslist, not Carvana.

Our response: We don't compete with mekina.net on volume. We compete on trust. A buyer choosing between an unverified listing on mekina.net and a battery-health-verified listing on EthioWheels will choose EthioWheels — especially for a purchase worth ETB 1.5M–4M.

Timeline to overcome: 3–6 months to establish brand recognition in the EV buyer community.

Challenge 2: “Nobody will pay for listings when mekina.net is free”

The threat: Sellers are used to free listings. Charging ETB 200–500 may face resistance.

The reality: Sellers pay when they see value. If a free listing on mekina.net gets 2 inquiries in 30 days and a premium listing on EthioWheels gets 15 inquiries in 30 days, sellers will pay.

Our response: - Start with a free tier to build supply - Prove value with the first 50 listings (track and share inquiry rates) - Introduce paid tiers only after sellers have experienced results - Offer the first paid listing free as a trial

Timeline to overcome: Month 2–3 after demonstrating inquiry volume.

Challenge 3: “I have no mechanic partners for inspections”

The threat: The inspection product requires mechanics. We have no relationships with any.

The reality: Mechanics need customers. We bring them customers. This is a straightforward value exchange.

Our response: - Visit BYD service centers and independent EV mechanics in Addis Ababa - Pitch: “We send you inspection jobs. You pay us 20–30% of the fee. No upfront cost.” - Start with 1 mechanic. Prove the model. Add more. - Provide them a simple Google Form to fill out after each inspection — we generate the PDF

Timeline to overcome: 2–4 weeks to sign first mechanic partner.

Challenge 4: “Banks won’t partner with an unknown startup”

The threat: Banks are conservative. They won’t sign a referral agreement with a platform that has zero track record.

The reality: We don’t need a formal agreement to start. We can send leads informally first.

Our response: - Phase 1: Add a “Contact bank directly” button with the bank’s public loan application link — no agreement needed - Phase 2: After 3 months of traffic data, approach banks with proof: “We sent 50 EV buyers to your loan page last month. Let’s formalize this.” - Phase 3: Negotiate a referral fee once the bank sees conversion data

Timeline to overcome: Month 4–6 for first formal bank partnership.

Challenge 5: “Internet shutdowns in Ethiopia”

The threat: Ethiopia has a history of internet disruptions during political events or exams. This can kill traffic and revenue for days or weeks.

The reality: This is a real risk that affects every digital business in Ethiopia equally. It is not unique to us.

Our response: - Build offline-capable features (Progressive Web App with service workers) - Maintain a Telegram channel as a backup communication channel - Diversify: SMS notifications for critical alerts (inspection ready, inquiry received) - Accept this as a country risk, not a business-ending risk

Timeline to mitigate: Build PWA features in Month 2–3.

Challenge 6: “I’m one person — I can’t do everything”

The threat: Building the product, doing sales, managing mechanics, handling customer support, creating content — this is too much for one person.

The reality: It is too much to do all at once. It is not too much to do sequentially.

Our response: - Month 1–2: Build only. No sales yet. - Month 3–4: Launch and do sales only. No new features. - Month 5–6: Stabilize operations. Automate what can be automated. - Month 7+: Use revenue to hire a part-time assistant (ETB 3,000–5,000/month) for customer support and mechanic coordination - Ruthlessly prioritize: only work on what directly generates revenue

Timeline to overcome: Month 7 — first hire from revenue.

Challenge 7: “EV buyers in Ethiopia are still a small market”

The threat: 100,000 EVs sounds large, but how many are being resold right now?

The reality: Most of the 100,000 EVs were purchased in 2023–2025. The first wave of resales is beginning now and will accelerate through 2027–2030 as early adopters upgrade. We are entering at exactly the right time — before the wave, not after.

Additionally: Even if only 1% of EVs change hands per month, that is 1,000 transactions/month — more than enough to build a business.

Timeline: The market grows with us. We don’t need it to be large on day one.

Challenge 8: “What if a bigger company copies us?”

The threat: Once we prove the model, mekina.net or a well-funded startup could copy the idea.

The reality: Trust is not copyable quickly. A brand that has issued 500 verified inspection reports, has relationships with 20 mechanics, and has 200 dealer accounts cannot be replicated in 3 months by a competitor with money.

Our response: - Move fast in the first 12 months to establish brand recognition
- Build the mechanic network as a supply-side moat - Build the dealer network as a supply-side moat - Publish data and content that establishes us as the authority on EV pricing in Ethiopia

Timeline: 12 months of consistent operation creates a moat that money alone cannot buy.

10. Technology Plan

10.1 Guiding Principle: Build the Minimum That Earns

Every feature must answer: “Does this directly help a seller list, a buyer trust, or us earn?” If not, it is not built yet.

10.2 Tech Stack (All Free Tier)

Layer	Technology	Why	Monthly Cost
Frontend	Next.js 14	SEO-critical for listings, fast, React-based	Free

Layer	Technology	Why	Monthly Cost
Hosting	Vercel	Free tier, auto-deploy from GitHub	Free
Database	Supabase (PostgreSQL)	Free 500MB, real-time, auth built-in	Free
File Storage	Cloudinary	Free 25GB for car photos	Free
Payments	Chapa	Telebirr + CBE Birr + bank, 2.9% fee	Free to integrate
Maps	OpenStreetMap + Leaflet.js	Free, no API key needed	Free
Email	Resend.com	3,000 emails/month free	Free
PDF Reports	React-PDF	Generate inspection reports in-browser	Free
Analytics	Umami (self-hosted on Vercel)	Privacy-friendly, free	Free
Domain	.et domain	Ethiopian identity	~ETB 500/year

Total monthly infrastructure cost: ETB 0–50

10.3 MVP Pages (6 Pages Only)

/	→ Homepage: search bar, featured listings, EV stats counter
/cars	→ All listings: filter by brand, price, battery health, location
/cars/[id]	→ Single listing: photos, specs, battery report, contact buttons
/sell	→ Submit listing form + Chapa payment
/inspection	→ Request inspection: form + payment + mechanic notification
/charging-map	→ OpenStreetMap with all known charging stations

No user accounts in MVP. No dashboard. No messaging system. Keep it simple.

10.4 Database Schema (MVP Only)

```
-- Listings table
CREATE TABLE listings (
  id          UUID PRIMARY KEY DEFAULT gen_random_uuid(),
```

```

title          TEXT NOT NULL,
price          INTEGER NOT NULL,          -- ETB
brand          TEXT,
model          TEXT,
year           INTEGER,
mileage        INTEGER,                  -- km
battery_health INTEGER,                  -- 0-100, null if not inspected
est_range      INTEGER,                  -- km per charge
location       TEXT,
seller_phone   TEXT NOT NULL,
seller_telegram TEXT,
images         TEXT[],                  -- Cloudinary URLs
is_verified    BOOLEAN DEFAULT false,
report_url     TEXT,                  -- PDF inspection report
tier           TEXT DEFAULT 'free',     -- free / basic / premium
status         TEXT DEFAULT 'active',
created_at     TIMESTAMPTZ DEFAULT now(),
expires_at     TIMESTAMPTZ DEFAULT now() + INTERVAL '30 days'
);

-- Inspection requests
CREATE TABLE inspections (
  id          UUID PRIMARY KEY DEFAULT gen_random_uuid(),
  listing_id  UUID REFERENCES listings(id),
  seller_phone TEXT NOT NULL,
  location    TEXT,
  preferred_date DATE,
  payment_ref TEXT,                  -- Chapa transaction ID
  mechanic_id UUID,
  status      TEXT DEFAULT 'pending', -- pending / scheduled / done
  created_at  TIMESTAMPTZ DEFAULT now()
);

-- Charging stations (crowdsourced)
CREATE TABLE charging_stations (
  id          UUID PRIMARY KEY DEFAULT gen_random_uuid(),
  name        TEXT,
  lat         DECIMAL(9,6) NOT NULL,
  lng         DECIMAL(9,6) NOT NULL,
  operator    TEXT,                  -- "Ethio Telecom", "Private"
  connector_type TEXT,              -- "CCS", "CHAdemo", "Type 2"
  speed_kw    INTEGER,
  is_operational BOOLEAN DEFAULT true,
  reported_by TEXT,
  created_at  TIMESTAMPTZ DEFAULT now()
);

```

10.5 Build Timeline

Week	What Gets Built
1–2	Project setup, Supabase schema, basic listing display
3–4	Listing submission form, Cloudinary image upload, Chapa payment
5	Single listing page, EV filters, mobile optimization
6	Charging map (Leaflet + OpenStreetMap), inspection request form
7	Amharic translation, SEO meta tags, sitemap
8	Admin panel (simple password-protected page), launch

Total build time: 8 weeks, solo developer, part-time possible

10.6 Amharic Support

Ethiopia is Amharic-first. The platform must support both languages from day one.

- Use `next-intl` for internationalization
- All UI strings in both Amharic and English
- Toggle in the header
- SEO pages in both languages (doubles organic search coverage)

11. Financial Projections

11.1 Assumptions

- No paid advertising (zero marketing budget)
- Growth driven by organic search, Telegram, and word of mouth
- Inspection partner takes 70% of inspection fee; we keep 30%
- Financing referral fee: ETB 800 average per converted loan
- Conversion rate: 10% of financing form submissions convert to loans

11.2 Monthly Revenue Projection

Month	Free Listings	Paid Listings	Inspections	Financing Leads	Total Revenue (ETB)
1	30	0	0	0	0
2	60	5×200	0	0	1,000
3	80	15×250	3×300	0	4,650
4	100	30×300	8×300	2×800	12,200
5	120	50×300	15×350	5×800	24,250
6	150	70×350	20×350	8×800	38,900
7	180	90×350	25×400	12×800	51,100
8	200	110×400	30×400	15×800	68,000
9	220	130×400	35×400	20×800	82,000
10	250	150×400	40×400	25×800	96,000
11	280	170×450	45×400	30×800	118,500
12	300	200×450	50×400	35×800	138,000

Year 1 Total Revenue: ~ETB 634,600 (~\$4,500 USD)

This is conservative. It assumes slow organic growth with no viral moments and no dealer accounts. A single dealer signing up (ETB 2,000/month, 20+ listings) changes these numbers significantly.

11.3 Year 2–3 Projection

Year	Monthly Revenue (ETB)	Annual Revenue (ETB)	Team Size
Year 1	$0 \rightarrow 138,000$	~634,600	1 (founder)
Year 2	$150,000 \rightarrow 400,000$	~3,300,000	2–3
Year 3	$400,000 \rightarrow 800,000$	~7,200,000	5–8

11.4 Operating Costs

Cost	Monthly (ETB)	Notes
Infrastructure	0–500	Free tiers cover early stage
Domain	~42	ETB 500/year
Personal expenses	Covered by Month 6	Founder salary from revenue
First hire (Month 7)	4,000–6,000	Part-time operations assistant
Marketing	0	Organic only until Month 9

Break-even: Month 3–4 (first ETB 5,000–10,000/month covers all costs)

Founder salary possible: Month 6–7 (ETB 30,000–50,000/month)

12. Risks

12.1 Risk Matrix

Risk	Probability	Impact	Mitigation
Internet shutdown	Medium	High	PWA offline mode, Telegram backup
mekina.net adds EV features	Medium	Medium	Move faster, build trust moat
Low initial seller adoption	High	Medium	Free tier + manual seeding
Bank partnership delays	High	Low	Start without formal agreement
Mechanic partner quality issues	Medium	High	Vet mechanics, standardize process
EV market growth slower than expected	Low	High	Diversify to fleet tools earlier
Government policy reversal on EV ban	Very Low	Very High	Unlikely; monitor policy
Chapa/payment gateway issues	Low	Medium	Integrate 2 payment providers

12.2 The Biggest Real Risk

The biggest risk is not competition or technology. It is **founder burnout from trying to do everything at once**.

Mitigation: Follow the phased plan strictly. Do not build features that are not in the current phase. Do not try to launch in multiple cities simultaneously. Do not try to raise investment before proving revenue. One thing at a time.

13. 12-Month Roadmap

Month 1–2: Build

- ☐ Set up Next.js + Supabase + Vercel + Chapa
- ☐ Build 6 core pages (mobile-first, Amharic + English)
- ☐ Integrate Cloudinary for image uploads
- ☐ Integrate Chapa for listing fee payments
- ☐ Build admin panel for managing listings

- ☐ Join 10+ Ethiopian car Telegram channels, observe market

Month 3: Launch

- ☐ Manually seed 20–30 EV listings (with seller permission from Telegram)
- ☐ Post launch announcement in all car groups
- ☐ Contact 20 EV sellers directly, offer free listing
- ☐ Sign first mechanic partner for inspections
- ☐ First paying customer (listing fee)

Month 4–5: First Revenue Streams

- ☐ Launch inspection product (partner mechanic + PDF report)
- ☐ Add “Apply for Financing” form (route to bank’s public page initially)
- ☐ Publish 3 Amharic SEO articles on EV buying guide
- ☐ Reach 100 active listings
- ☐ First dealer account signed

Month 6–7: Stabilize

- ☐ ETB 30,000–50,000/month revenue
- ☐ Hire part-time operations assistant
- ☐ Formalize first bank/MFI referral partnership
- ☐ Launch charging station map (crowdsourced)
- ☐ Reach 5 mechanic partners across Addis Ababa

Month 8–10: Scale

- ☐ 200+ active listings
- ☐ 10+ dealer accounts
- ☐ ETB 70,000–100,000/month revenue
- ☐ Begin outreach to Dire Dawa and Adama dealers
- ☐ Launch basic fleet inquiry form

Month 11–12: Prepare for Year 2

- ☐ ETB 120,000–150,000/month revenue
 - ☐ Document all processes for team handoff
 - ☐ Evaluate seed funding options (Ethiopian angels, diaspora investors, African VC)
 - ☐ Plan fleet management SaaS product for Year 2
 - ☐ Consider regional expansion (Djibouti, Eritrea)
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14. Future Vision (Year 2–5)

Year 2: Deepen the Platform

- **Fleet Management SaaS:** Monthly subscription for ride-hail operators and taxi fleets. Battery health tracking, charging cost analytics, maintenance alerts. ETB 500–2,000/vehicle/month.
- **EV Price Index:** Publish monthly EV pricing data for Ethiopia. Become the authoritative source. Banks, insurers, and government will cite this data.
- **Insurance Partnership:** Connect EV buyers to insurance products. Earn referral fee per policy.
- **Expand to 3 cities:** Dire Dawa, Adama, Hawassa — all growing EV markets.

Year 3: Regional Expansion

Ethiopia's EV leadership is influencing neighboring countries. Djibouti, Eritrea, and Sudan are watching. The platform, brand, and mechanic network model can be replicated in these markets with minimal additional investment.

- **Djibouti:** Small market, high income, port city with EV imports
- **Kenya:** Autochek is there but not EV-focused. Opportunity exists.
- **Pan-East Africa EV Network:** The long-term vision — the trusted EV marketplace for the Horn of Africa and East Africa.

Year 4–5: The Data Business

By Year 4, EthioWheels will have: - 50,000+ EV transaction records - Battery health data on thousands of vehicles - Charging station usage patterns - EV pricing history across all models

This data is worth more than the marketplace itself. Potential buyers: - Insurance companies (actuarial data for EV policies) - Banks (EV loan risk modeling) - Government (policy planning) - EV manufacturers (market intelligence) - International research organizations

The Exit Scenarios

Scenario	Timeline	Who Buys
Acquisition by Autochek	Year 3–4	They want Ethiopia market entry
Acquisition by African bank	Year 3–5	They want EV financing data
Series A funding	Year 2–3	African VC (TLcom, 4DX, Partech)
Stay profitable, no exit	Ongoing	Founder's choice

15. Why This Wins

The Structural Advantages

- 1. Government is your co-founder.** The Ethiopian government has staked its energy policy on EV adoption. Any platform that accelerates EV adoption is aligned with national interest. This means potential grants, regulatory support, and government partnerships that no competitor can easily replicate.
- 2. The ICE ban is irreversible.** Unlike most markets where EVs compete with ICE vehicles, Ethiopia has eliminated the competition by law. Every car sold from 2024 onward is electric. The used EV market will only grow.
- 3. Trust is the product, not listings.** Anyone can build a listing site. Nobody in Ethiopia has built a trust layer for EVs. The first platform to issue 1,000 verified inspection reports owns the market's trust — and trust is the hardest thing to copy.
- 4. The timing is perfect.** 100,000 EVs are on the road now. The first wave of resales is beginning. We are entering at the inflection point — early enough to establish brand, late enough that the market exists.
- 5. Software skills are the right skills.** This business does not require capital, physical infrastructure, or a large team to start. It requires the ability to build a web platform, integrate payments, and automate workflows. That is exactly what we have.

The Honest Summary

This is not a guaranteed success. No business is. But the conditions are as favorable as they get:

- A market that is being forced to transition by government policy
- No credible competitor in the specific niche
- A problem (trust) that software can solve
- Revenue possible from month 1
- Zero capital required to start
- Government alignment
- Growing market (100K EVs → 500K by 2030)

The only thing standing between this idea and a real business is **30 focused days of building and 30 focused days of selling.**

Appendix: Quick Reference

Key Numbers to Remember

- Ethiopia used car market: **\$494M (2026)**
- EVs on Ethiopian roads: **100,000+**

- Government EV target: **500,000 by 2030**
- Charging stations planned: **2,300 by 2030**
- Current charging hubs: **4 (Ethio Telecom)**
- ICE import ban: **January 2024**
- Grid renewable energy: **96%**

Key Competitors to Monitor

- mekina.net (main local competitor)
- Autochek (if they enter Ethiopia)
- Any Ethio Telecom digital services expansion

Key Partners to Pursue

- EV mechanics / BYD service centers (inspection)
- Awash Bank, Abyssinia Bank (financing)
- Ethio Telecom (charging data API)
- Ethiopian Ministry of Transport (data partnership)
- Chapa (payments)

Key Metrics to Track Weekly

- Number of active listings
- Number of listing fee payments
- Number of inspection requests
- Number of financing form submissions
- Organic search traffic (Google Search Console)
- Telegram channel followers

This proposal was prepared for internal planning purposes. All financial projections are estimates based on market research and comparable African marketplace benchmarks. Actual results will vary.

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